Alexandra Sandström

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Research Interests: Political Economy, Economic History, Development Economics, Economics of Education

CURRENT POSITION

Uppsala University, Department of Economics (Uppsala, Sweden) *Aug. 2022–Jun. 2027 (expected)*
Ph.D. Candidate in Economics
Main Advisor: Luca Repetto
Secondary Advisor: Eva Mörk
Affiliations: Uppsala Immigration Lab (UIL), Uppsala History of Inequality and Labor Lab (UHILL)

PREVIOUS EDUCATION

Harvard University (Cambridge, MA, USA) *Spring 2025*
Visiting Fellow, Harvard Business School
Host: Marco Tabellini

Ludwig Maximilian University (Munich, Germany) *2019–2021*
MSc in Economics

Umeå University (Umeå, Sweden) *2016–2019*
BSc in Governance and Administration

Sabanci University (Istanbul, Turkey) *Spring 2018*
Visiting Student

WORKING PAPERS

Language of Instruction, Integration, and Identity: Evidence from Sweden's Tornedalians (JMP)

Abstract: How does language of instruction shape social integration and national identity? I study the introduction of primary schools with Swedish, rather than Finnish, as the language of instruction in late nineteenth-century Tornedalen, a predominantly Finnish-speaking region of Sweden bordering Finland. Using linked censuses and variation across villages and cohorts, I estimate the effects of exposure to Swedish-only schooling. Exposure increased integration, as reflected in marriage patterns and reduced ethnic residential segregation, while shifting identity away from Swedish and toward Finnish, as measured by naming choices and military employment. I find no effects on income, further education, or language use at home. The evidence is consistent with intergroup contact in schools promoting integration and with Swedish-only instruction making linguistic differences more salient, thereby generating unintended social identity responses. At the village level, school openings increased Swedish naming and decreased Finnish language use at home. Together, these findings illustrate how nation-building through education can have diverse effects. They emphasize the distinction between the social and cultural dimensions of assimilation, as well as between individual exposure to schooling and broader community-level responses. More broadly, the findings underscore the importance of considering intergroup contact alongside learning when designing language-of-instruction policies.

The State Made War, and War Made the Rebels: WWI Mortality and Irish Independence
with F. Carozzi and L. Repetto

Abstract: Can the human costs of fighting for a state spur later participation in rebellion against it? We study this question in Ireland, where communities sent men to fight for Britain in World War I and soon after supplied rebels in the War of Independence. We instrument local WWI death rates using a shift-share instrument based on regiment-level mortality shocks and find that a one-standard-deviation increase in the WWI death rate raises the rebel rate by about 1.4 additional rebels per 100 inhabitants, relative to a sample mean of 1.5. The increase in rebel participation is stronger in what became the Irish Free State than in Northern Ireland, suggesting that pre-existing political divisions influenced responses to wartime losses. We find little evidence that the effect is driven by returning servicemen joining the rebellion. An event-study analysis of children's given names reveals WWI mortality led to a shift towards Irish and away from British cultural identity.

WORK IN PROGRESS

First Language Training and Integration
with S. Strömberg

Nationalist Organizations, Cultural Revival, and Political Mobilization: The Gaelic League in Ireland
with F. Carozzi and L. Repetto

PUBLICATIONS

Berggren, Niclas, Christian Bjørnskov, and Alexandra Sandström (2026). The Rule of Law Predicts Trust in Journalists. *Journal of Law and Economics*, 69(2), 361–385.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Uppsala University

Development Economics (BSc level), *Lecturer and Teaching Assistant* *2023–2024*
Macroeconomics (BSc level), *Teaching Assistant* *2023–2026*
Fundamentals of Environmental Economics (MSc level), *Teaching Assistant* *Fall 2024*

PAST EMPLOYMENT

Research Institute of Industrial Economics (Stockholm, Sweden) *Oct. 2021–Aug. 2022*
Research Assistant

Max Planck Institute (Munich, Germany) *Jan. 2020–Sep. 2021*
Part-time Research Assistant, Institute for Social Law and Social Policy

GRANTS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Jan Wallander and Tom Hedelius Foundation
Hedelius Scholarship for doctoral studies abroad, 295,000 SEK *2024*

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Organizer, Graduate Student Brownbag Seminar Series, Department of Economics, Uppsala University *2024*

Board Member, PhD Association, Department of Economics, Uppsala University *2023–2024*

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

2026: Uppsala History of Inequality and Labor Lab (UHILL) Workshop; Economic History Society Annual Conference; Stockholm–Uppsala Education Economics Workshop; Uppsala Economic History Workshop; Nordic Conference in Development Economics; EEA Congress

2025: Harvard Graduate Student Workshop in Economic History; Center for European Studies Harvard Ph.D. and Postdoctoral Conference on European Development; Political Economy of Conflict and Redistribution Summer School; ASREC Europe Graduate Student Workshop

2024: Uppsala University Department of Peace and Conflict Research Brownbag; Association of Swedish Development Economists Conference

REFERENCES

Luca Repetto
Uppsala University

Eva Mörk
Uppsala University

Marco Tabellini
Harvard Business School

Mounir Karadja
Uppsala University